Nancy and François headed for their table, but Mrs. Mitterrand stood frozen, even after a butler motioned at her that she was to walk toward our table. I whispered, “We’re supposed to go over there to the other side.” But she wouldn’t move. She said something to me very quietly in French, which I didn’t understand. Then she repeated it and I shook my head. I still didn’t know what she was saying; suddenly an interpreter ran up to us and said, “She’s telling you that you’re standing on her gown.”

Besides making those big state dinners more relaxed, Nancy started holding smaller dinners upstairs for some of our guests, including, among others, Prince Charles and the crown prince of Japan. Usually, we invited thirty or so people to these dinners upstairs in the family dining room. Here the routine was that of a private dinner at home: first, cocktails in the yellow oval room, and then over to the dining room for dinner, with sometimes a little musical entertainment afterward.

Most of the time, I should emphasize, our dinners in the White House were not this fancy, although when there was a state dinner coming up, we’d sometimes go across the hall to the family dining room for a “rehearsal.” Nancy liked to have a dry run, to make sure the menu was right for the next guests.

One of the occupational hazards of being president, I learned, is shaking hands. At some receptions in the White House—for members of Congress and their families, the press, and so forth—I’d have to shake as many as one thousand hands a night. Believe it or not, that can leave you with a sore hand.

Another problem: I’m not very good at remembering faces and names. In national politics, you meet so many people around the country that it’s impossible to remember them all, and as a result I was always afraid I was going to slight someone. On a campaign trip, I might visit five or six states